

Global Employee Handbook and Policy Manual

Chapter 1: Corporate Philosophy, Onboarding, and the Employment Relationship

Section 1.1: Mission, Vision, and Core Values

This Global Employee Handbook and Policy Manual serves as the foundational governance document of the organization.¹ The primary objective is to define the terms of the professional relationship, clarify operational requirements, and outline the statutory obligations of the employer and the workforce.¹

The organization operates under a unified vision to achieve leadership in its industry while maintaining compliance, operational integrity, and respect.¹ To realize this vision, the corporate culture is built on transparency, legal adherence, and professionalism.¹

Upon onboarding, every employee is required to read, understand, and comply with the directives set forth in this handbook.¹ The human resources department remains the primary resource for any clarifications regarding the interpretation or execution of these policies.¹

Section 1.2: Recruitment, Selection, and Placement Process

The organization is committed to a structured and transparent recruitment process to attract and select highly qualified candidates.¹ The hiring process is designed to ensure equity, eliminate bias, and comply with all applicable local and international labor standards.¹

Phase	Operational Step	Primary Responsibility	Key Focus Areas
Phase I	Job Requisition and Sourcing Strategy ²	Department Head & HR ²	Draft job description, write job ad, identify sourcing channels (internal vs external). ²
Phase II	Screening and Interviewing ²	Talent Acquisition Specialist ²	Review resumes, conduct initial screening, schedule structured panel interviews. ²

Phase III	Pre-Employment Verification ²	Compliance Officer & HR ²	Execute academic credential checks, past employment audits, and references. ²
Phase IV	Formal Offer and Onboarding ¹	Human Resources Director ²	Issue official offer letter, initiate background checks, complete onboarding paperwork. ¹

The organization prioritizes internal talent mobility, encouraging eligible employees to apply for open roles before external sourcing is initiated.² All open positions are posted on the internal corporate portal for a minimum of ten working days.

Section 1.3: Pre-Employment Screening and Candidate Referrals

To safeguard the integrity of the workplace and protect corporate assets, all job offers are contingent upon the successful completion of a comprehensive pre-employment screening.²

The screening process includes verification of educational credentials, professional licensing, past employment history, and references.²

Where permitted by local law, background checks may also include criminal record verifications and credit history reviews for roles involving financial or sensitive data access.² Any discrepancy or falsification of information discovered during the screening process will result in the immediate withdrawal of the employment offer or, if already employed, summary dismissal.²

To support talent acquisition, the organization operates an Employee Referral Program.² Employees who refer qualified candidates who are subsequently hired and successfully complete their probationary period may be eligible for a referral bonus, subject to program terms and guidelines.²

Section 1.4: Onboarding Protocols and Initial IT Setup

The onboarding process is designed to integrate new hires into the organization's culture and operational workflows.¹ On his or her first day of employment, a new hire must complete all required statutory paperwork, including tax withholding forms, benefits enrollment, and emergency contact declarations.¹

The initial onboarding sequence includes:

- **Introduction to Leadership:** New employees receive a formal introduction to the leadership structure and the history of the business.¹
- **Policy Review:** A comprehensive review of the Code of Conduct and security protocols is conducted by the human resources team.¹

- **IT Asset Allocation:** The IT support team provisions all necessary hardware, software licenses, and secure access credentials.¹
- **Onboarding Plan:** The direct supervisor provides a structured performance plan detailing the employee's initial responsibilities.¹

Employees are expected to complete all assigned onboarding and compliance training modules within their first thirty days of employment.¹

Section 1.5: Employment Contract Types and Classifications

The organization maintains distinct employment classifications to align operational needs with legal guidelines.¹ The determination of an employee's classification is established at the time of recruitment and is explicitly stated in the employment agreement.² These classifications govern the applicability of specific company benefits, overtime eligibility, and leave accruals.²

- **Full-Time Employees:** Individuals who are regularly scheduled to work at least 30 to 48 hours per week, depending on local statutory baselines.² Full-time employees are eligible for the standard suite of corporate benefits and leave entitlements.²
- **Part-Time Employees:** Individuals who are regularly scheduled to work less than 30 hours per week.² Part-time employees may be eligible for a pro-rata allocation of benefits and leave, subject to local legal requirements.⁵
- **Probationary Employees:** Newly hired personnel whose performance is evaluated during an initial trial period (typically six months) before confirmation of permanent status.⁶
- **Contractual and Temporary Staff:** Individuals engaged for a specific project, a defined duration, or a seasonal period.² Contractual staff are governed by the terms of their service agreement and are subject to statutory minima under local labor acts.⁴

Chapter 2: US Federal Labor Standards and Regulatory Compliance

Section 2.1: The Fair Labor Standards Act (FLSA) Framework

For personnel employed within the United States, the organization operates in strict compliance with the Fair Labor Standards Act (FLSA).³ The FLSA establishes federal standards for minimum wage, overtime pay, recordkeeping, and youth employment.³

Under the FLSA, all positions within the organization are classified as either exempt or non-exempt based on their job duties, salary level, and salary basis.³ This classification determines an employee's eligibility for overtime compensation.³

Section 2.2: White-Collar Exemptions and Overtime Rules

To qualify as exempt from overtime requirements under the FLSA, an employee must meet the three statutory tests for "white-collar" exemptions: the Salary Level Test, the Salary Basis Test, and the Primary Duties Test.³

Exemption Category	Salary Basis Requirement	Primary Duty Requirements
Executive Exemption ³	Paid a predetermined, fixed salary not subject to reduction based on quality/quantity of work. ³	Managing the enterprise or a recognized department; directing the work of at least two full-time employees; authority to hire or fire. ³
Administrative Exemption ³	Paid a predetermined, fixed salary not subject to reduction based on quality/quantity of work. ³	Performing office or non-manual work directly related to management or general business operations; exercising discretion and independent judgment on significant matters. ³
Professional Exemption ³	Paid a predetermined, fixed salary not subject to reduction based on quality/quantity of work. ³	Performing work requiring advanced knowledge in a field of science or learning acquired through prolonged specialized instruction. ³
Computer Exemption ³	Paid on a salary or fee basis, or an hourly rate of not less than \$27.63 per hour. ³	Performing systems analysis, software engineering, programming, or database design. ³
Outside Sales Exemption ³	No salary level requirement. ³	Making sales or obtaining orders/contracts; regularly working away from the employer's place of business. ³

Non-exempt employees must be compensated for all hours worked.³ For hours worked in excess of 40 hours in a single workweek, non-exempt employees must be paid overtime at a rate of 1.5 times their regular rate of pay.³

The organization implements a strict "Safe Harbor" policy to prevent improper salary deductions for exempt employees.³ If an exempt employee believes an improper deduction has been made, they must report the matter to human resources, which will investigate and reimburse any improper deductions.³

Section 2.3: The Davis-Bacon Act and Government Contracting Compliance

When participating in federal government contracts, the organization complies with the Davis-Bacon Act.³ The Davis-Bacon Act requires contractors and subcontractors performing on federally funded contracts in excess of \$2,000 for the construction, alteration, or repair of public buildings or public works to pay their laborers and mechanics no less than the locally prevailing wages and fringe benefits.³

The prevailing wage rates are determined by the U.S. Department of Labor and are incorporated into the contract terms.³ The compliance team maintains certified payroll records and submits them weekly to the contracting agency, as required by law.³

Section 2.4: National Labor Relations Act (NLRA) and Labor Unions

The organization respects the rights of employees under the National Labor Relations Act (NLRA), also known as the Wagner Act.³ The NLRA guarantees employees the right to self-organize, form, join, or assist labor organizations, bargain collectively through representatives of their own choosing, and engage in other concerted activities for the purpose of collective bargaining or mutual aid and protection.³

The organization complies with all key provisions of the NLRA and subsequent amendments, including:

- **Taft-Hartley Act:** Prohibits unfair labor practices by unions and outlaws "closed shops" where union membership is a condition of hiring.³ It also guarantees the right of employees to refrain from union activities, except where a valid union security agreement is in place.³
- **Landrum-Griffin Act:** Protects the rights of individual union members from corrupt or discriminatory labor practices and ensures transparency in union financial reporting.³
- **Protection of Concerted Activity:** The organization does not interfere with, restrain, or coerce employees in the exercise of their rights under the NLRA. No policy in this handbook is intended to restrict employees from discussing their wages, working conditions, or other terms of employment.³

Chapter 3: Working Hours, Attendance, and Operations (Indian Jurisdictions)

Section 3.1: Karnataka Shops and Commercial Establishments Act Compliance

For personnel employed within the State of Karnataka, India, the organization's working hours, leave structures, and operational procedures are governed by the Karnataka Shops and Commercial Establishments Act, 1961, and its corresponding rules.⁴

The organization maintains registration with the Karnataka Labour Department and is subject to

routine inspections to verify compliance with wage registers, attendance records, and leave books.⁴

Section 3.2: Standard Working Hours, Shift Rostering, and Break Intervals

The standard operating schedule is designed to optimize operational efficiency while respecting employee health and statutory limits.⁴ The standard daily work shift is limited to 9 hours, and the weekly work shift is limited to 48 hours.⁴

Standard Parameter	Commercial Office Operations	Factory and Manufacturing Operations
Daily Shift Limit	Maximum 9 hours (excluding breaks) ⁴	Maximum 10 hours (excluding breaks) ⁴
Weekly Shift Limit	Maximum 48 hours ⁴	Maximum 60 hours ⁴
Mandatory Rest Interval	30 minutes after 5 continuous hours of work ⁴	30 minutes after 5 continuous hours of work ⁴
Weekly Rest Day	1 mandatory day off per week (typically Sunday) ⁴	1 mandatory day off per week ⁴

Department heads are responsible for creating and distributing shift rosters.⁴ Any modifications to a scheduled shift must be communicated to the affected employees at least 48 hours in advance, except in cases of unforeseen operational emergencies.⁴

Section 3.3: Overtime Compensation and Quarterly Statutory Caps

Overtime work is strictly regulated and requires prior written authorization from the department head and the human resources department.⁴ Employees must provide their prior consent before working overtime hours.⁴

Overtime hours are compensated at double (2x) the employee's regular rate of wages, calculated on the basis of basic salary and dearness allowance.⁴

The maximum allowable overtime is capped by law:

- **Shops and Commercial Establishments:** Overtime hours must not exceed 90 hours in any single calendar quarter.⁴
- **Factories and Industrial Units:** Overtime hours must not exceed 120 hours in any single calendar quarter.⁴

The HR department audit team monitors overtime logs monthly to ensure compliance with these statutory caps.⁴

Section 3.4: Night Shift Operations, Women's Employment, and Safety Infrastructure

To support 24/7 client operations, the organization operates night shifts, defined as any work schedule falling between 7:00 PM and 6:00 AM.⁴ While night shift assignments are distributed based on operational needs, the employment of women during night shifts is subject to strict regulatory compliance.⁴

The organization has implemented a comprehensive safety infrastructure for women working during night shifts, including ⁴:

- **Secure Transportation:** The organization provides secure, door-to-door GPS-tracked vehicle transport.⁴ A security escort is mandatory if a female employee is the first to be picked up or the last to be dropped off.⁴
- **Designated Facilities:** The physical office maintains separate, secure rest zones and designated, key-card-restricted washrooms for female employees.⁴
- **Emergency Response:** A 24/7 security desk is operational, with direct links to local emergency services.⁴
- **SEZ/IT Park Exemptions:** The organization maintains the necessary state exemptions and compliance filings required to run round-the-clock operations in Special Economic Zones (SEZs) and IT Parks.⁴

Chapter 4: Comprehensive Time-Off and Leave Management

Section 4.1: Statutory Leave Entitlements and Accumulation Under State Laws

The organization's leave policy is designed to support employee health, work-life balance, and statutory compliance under the Karnataka Shops and Commercial Establishments Act, 1961.⁹ Employees accrue different categories of leave based on their service tenure and status.⁵

Leave Category	Annual Allotment	Accrual Method	Carry-Forward Policy	Encashment Policy
Earned Leave (EL)	12 to 18 days (dependent on days worked) ⁵	1 day for every 20 days of actual work ⁵	Carry forward up to a maximum of 45 days ⁵	Fully encashable at the time of separation or retirement ⁵
Casual Leave	6 days ⁵	Credited	Lapses on	Non-encashabl

(CL)		upfront at the start of the year ⁵	December 31; no carry-forward ⁵	e ⁵
Sick Leave (SL)	6 days ⁵	Credited upfront at the start of the year ⁵	Lapses on December 31; no carry-forward ⁵	Non-encashable ⁵

Earned Leave starts accruing from the date of joining.⁵ An employee must work a minimum of 240 days in a calendar year to qualify for their full Earned Leave entitlement for that year.⁵

Section 4.2: Earned, Casual, and Sick Leave Framework

The organization has established clear guidelines for requesting and utilizing leaves to ensure operational continuity⁵:

- **Earned Leave:** Employees must submit a written request for Earned Leave through the corporate HR portal at least 10 days before the planned leave begins.⁵ Earned Leave requests may be deferred by management based on critical project deadlines or team staffing levels.⁵
- **Casual Leave:** Intended for unexpected personal matters.⁵ Employees can apply for Casual Leave on the same day or one day in advance, subject to manager approval.⁵ Casual Leave cannot be combined with Earned Leave or Sick Leave.
- **Sick Leave:** Intended for personal illness or medical emergencies.⁵ Employees must notify their supervisor of their absence as early as possible on the day of the leave.⁵ A medical certificate from a registered medical practitioner is required for any Sick Leave exceeding two consecutive days.⁵

Section 4.3: Maternity Benefit Act Compliance and Parental Support

The organization provides robust maternity and parental benefits in compliance with the Maternity Benefit Act, 1961, and its subsequent amendments.⁴ Female employees who have worked for the organization for at least 80 days in the 12 months preceding the expected delivery date are eligible for paid maternity leave.⁴

The maternity leave allocations are as follows:

- **Standard Maternity Leave:** Eligible female employees receive 26 weeks of fully paid maternity leave for their first and second surviving children.⁴ Up to 8 weeks of this leave can be taken before the expected delivery date.⁵
- **Subsequent Maternity Leave:** For the third child onwards, the paid leave entitlement is restricted to 12 weeks.⁴
- **Adoption and Surrogacy Leave:** Adoptive mothers (adopting a child under three months of age) and commissioning mothers (in surrogacy arrangements) are entitled to 12 weeks of paid leave, starting from the date the child is physically handed over.⁵

- **Medical Complications and Miscarriage:** In the event of a miscarriage or medical termination of pregnancy, the employee is entitled to 6 weeks of paid leave immediately following the procedure, subject to medical certification.⁵
- **Crèche Infrastructure:** For offices employing 50 or more personnel, the organization provides access to a certified crèche facility.¹² Female employees are permitted four visits daily to the crèche, which includes their designated rest intervals.¹²

While not mandated by regional labor acts for the private sector, the organization provides 10 days of paid paternity leave for male employees with fewer than two surviving children.⁵ This leave must be taken within 90 days of the child's birth or adoption.⁵

Section 4.4: Bereavement Leave and National Holiday Rosters

The organization provides support for employees experiencing personal loss.⁵ Employees are eligible for 3 days of paid bereavement leave for the death of an immediate family member, defined as a spouse, child, parent, or sibling.⁵ Additional unpaid leave may be granted at the manager's and HR's discretion based on personal circumstances.⁵

The organization also observes 8 to 10 declared national and festival holidays each calendar year, in accordance with state-notified lists.⁴ This includes mandatory national holidays such as Republic Day, Independence Day, and Gandhi Jayanti.⁴ The complete holiday calendar is published by the human resources department in December for the upcoming year.⁴

Chapter 5: Employee Code of Conduct and Workplace Professionalism

Section 5.1: Professional Code of Conduct and Ethical Expectations

The organization requires all employees to maintain professional standards of conduct, integrity, and ethical behavior.¹ The code of conduct is designed to ensure a productive, safe, and respectful work environment.¹

Key conduct expectations include:

- **Professional Demeanor:** Employees must interact with colleagues, clients, and partners with respect.² Any form of verbal abuse, physical intimidation, or bullying is prohibited.²
- **Workplace Violence:** The organization has a zero-tolerance policy for workplace violence, including threats, physical altercations, or carrying weapons on company premises.²
- **Drug-Free Workplace:** The manufacturing, distribution, possession, or use of illegal substances on company premises or during working hours is strictly prohibited.²

Section 5.2: Dress Code and Corporate Representation

Employees are expected to maintain professional standards of dress and personal grooming.¹ The default dress code is business professional or smart casual, appropriate to the employee's role and client-facing responsibilities.¹

Employees representing the organization at external events, conferences, or client meetings must dress in professional business attire and conduct themselves as ambassadors of the brand.²

Section 5.3: Conflict of Interest and Secondary Employment Guidelines

Employees must avoid any situation where their personal interests conflict with the interests of the organization.² A conflict of interest may arise when an employee has a financial or personal relationship with a competitor, vendor, client, or business partner of the organization.²

Key rules regarding conflicts of interest include:

- **Secondary Employment:** Full-time employees are prohibited from holding secondary employment or engaging in outside business activities that conflict with their responsibilities to the organization, unless they receive prior written approval from the human resources department.
- **Gifts and Inducements:** Employees may not accept substantial gifts, hospitality, or financial favors from any vendor, client, or competitor.¹³
- **Use of Corporate Resources:** Company-issued equipment, proprietary data, and working hours must not be used for personal business ventures.²

Section 5.4: Workplace Fraternization and Employment of Relatives

To prevent conflicts of interest, favoritism, and claims of harassment, the organization has established guidelines for personal relationships in the workplace.²

- **Fraternization:** While the organization respects employee privacy, personal romantic or dating relationships between employees where one individual has supervisory or reporting authority over the other are prohibited.² Employees in a reporting relationship who enter into a romantic partnership must disclose the relationship to human resources, which will work to adjust reporting lines or transfer one of the individuals.²
- **Employment of Relatives:** The employment of close relatives within the same department or reporting line is restricted.¹ Close relatives are defined as parents, siblings, children, spouses, or in-laws.⁵ Relatives may be employed by the organization only if there is no direct or indirect reporting relationship or conflict of interest.²

Section 5.5: Solicitation, Distribution, and Visitor Policies

To minimize disruptions and maintain a professional work environment, the organization has established rules for solicitation and distribution of literature on company premises.²

- **Solicitation:** The solicitation of funds, promotion of outside commercial ventures, or collection of signatures is prohibited on company premises during working hours.²
- **Distribution of Literature:** The distribution of non-corporate literature, flyers, or promotional material is prohibited on company premises, except with prior written approval from the facilities and human resources departments.²
- **Workplace Visitors:** Unauthorized visitors are not permitted in secure work areas.² All

visitors must register at the reception desk, obtain a visitor badge, and be escorted by an employee at all times.²

Chapter 6: Cybersecurity, Digital Assets, and Corporate Communication

Section 6.1: Use of Corporate IT Equipment, Networks, and VPNs

Protecting corporate data and intellectual property is critical.² Employees who use company-issued digital devices, communication systems, and internet networks must comply with the organization's cybersecurity protocols.¹

The organization implements the following digital security controls:

- **Authorized Use:** Company-issued laptops, mobile phones, and storage devices must be used primarily for business operations.² Personal use must be kept to a minimum and must not interfere with job performance.
- **Network Security:** Employees are prohibited from connecting company-issued equipment to unsecured public networks unless a corporate Virtual Private Network (VPN) is active.²
- **Access Control:** Sharing access credentials, passwords, or security tokens is a severe security violation.² Multi-factor authentication must be enabled on all corporate accounts.
- **Software Installation:** Only software approved and licensed by the IT department may be installed on corporate assets. Unauthorized file-sharing software, gaming applications, or unverified tools are prohibited.
- **Physical Device Security:** Laptops and mobile devices must be locked when left unattended.² Loss of any company-issued equipment must be reported to the IT department within two hours of discovery.²

Section 6.2: Data Security, Encryption, and Document Retention Policies

To protect proprietary data, the organization has established strict protocols for data security and encryption²:

- **Data Encryption:** All sensitive data, including client financial records, employee personal data, and proprietary code, must be encrypted both in transit and at rest.²
- **Access Restricting:** Access to sensitive data is restricted based on the principle of least privilege.² Employees are only granted access to data necessary for their specific job functions.²
- **Document Shredding:** Physical documents containing confidential information must be shredded when they are no longer required for business operations.²
- **Data Backups:** Automated, secure data backups are performed daily by the IT department to prevent data loss.¹⁷

Section 6.3: Acceptable Internet and Personal Mobile Device Usage

The organization provides internet access for business-related research and communication.²

- **Internet Usage:** Employees are prohibited from accessing websites that contain obscene, hateful, or illegal content while using company networks or devices.² Downloading unauthorized files or media is prohibited.²
- **Bring Your Own Device (BYOD):** Employees who access corporate networks or email on their personal mobile devices must enroll their devices in the organization's Mobile Device Management (MDM) program. This program enforces security controls, including PIN locks and remote-wipe capabilities, to protect corporate data in the event of device loss.

Section 6.4: Corporate Email, Chat Platforms, and Professional Communication

Corporate communication channels, including email, instant messaging systems, and collaboration platforms, are corporate property.¹ The organization reserves the right to monitor and audit these systems to ensure compliance with security and ethical standards.²

- **Email Usage:** Corporate email accounts must be used for professional purposes.¹ Sending harassing, obscene, or defamatory material, or distributing unsolicited mass mailings, is a violation of company policy.²
- **Chat Platforms:** Informal communication on corporate chat platforms must remain professional and respectful.¹ The organization's anti-harassment and anti-discrimination policies apply fully to all digital communications.²
- **Confidentiality:** Employees must not transmit unencrypted sensitive data or trade secrets over external email or public messaging platforms.²

Section 6.5: Social Media Integrity and Representation

The organization respects the rights of employees to maintain personal social media accounts, but expects them to act responsibly to protect the company's brand and reputation.¹

- **Confidentiality:** Employees must not post confidential or proprietary information, including financial metrics, product roadmaps, client lists, or trade secrets, on personal social media accounts.¹
- **Corporate Representation:** No employee may speak on behalf of the organization on social media or to public press outlets unless they are a designated corporate spokesperson.
- **Disclaimer:** If an employee lists their association with the organization on a personal blog or social media profile, they must include a clear disclaimer stating that the opinions expressed are their own and do not represent the views of the organization.

Chapter 7: Global Data Privacy and Information Security (DPDPA 2023 Compliance)

Section 7.1: Personal Data Processing and Legitimate Use Grounds

The organization handles employee personal data in compliance with the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023, and its associated regulations.¹⁶ In accordance with Section 7(1)(i) of the Act, the processing of employee personal data for purposes related to employment is recognized as a "legitimate use".¹⁶

Therefore, the organization is exempt from obtaining explicit, consent-manager-based consent for standard human resource operations, provided that the processing is directly tied to the employment relationship or protecting the employer from loss or liability.¹⁶

Operational Category	Data Elements Processed	Legal Basis (DPDP Act)	Retention Period Standard
Payroll & Benefits	Bank details, Tax filings, PF numbers, salary histories ¹⁷	Legitimate Use (Section 7) ¹⁷	Tax and social security statutory retention periods ¹⁷
Operational Security	Biometric logs, CCTV, network activity, email archives ²	Legitimate Use (Safeguarding against liability) ¹⁶	90 days to 1 year (dependent on storage/legal holds)
Healthcare & Benefits	Medical certificates, health insurance records ⁵	Legitimate Use (Benefit provision) ¹⁶	Duration of active employment plus statutory tail periods ¹⁷
Talent Acquisition	Resumes, background verification reports, reference checks ²	Consent-based (pre-employment phase) ¹⁷	Erased within 6 months of rejection, unless consent to retain is active

While explicit consent is not required for core employment operations, the organization must provide a clear, stand-alone Privacy Notice before or alongside data collection.¹⁷

Section 7.2: The Mandatory Employee Privacy Notice Framework

Under the DPDP Act, the organization is required to provide a clear, stand-alone Privacy Notice to all employees describing how their personal data is collected, processed, and shared.¹⁷

The Privacy Notice must include ¹⁷:

- **Categories of Data:** A detailed description of the personal data collected, including contact information, banking details, performance evaluations, and healthcare records.¹⁷

- **Purpose of Processing:** The specific operational and legal reasons for processing the data, such as payroll administration, benefits provision, and workplace security.¹⁷
- **Third-Party Sharing:** A list of third-party service providers with whom the data may be shared, including payroll processors and health insurance vendors.¹⁷
- **Employee Rights:** Information on how employees can access, correct, or request the erasure of their personal data.¹⁷
- **Grievance Redressal:** Contact details of the Data Protection Officer (DPO) and the process for filing complaints regarding data handling.¹⁷

The Privacy Notice must be written in plain language and be accessible in English and state-notified vernacular languages.¹⁷

Section 7.3: Technical Safeguards, Data Minimization, and Retention Boundaries

The organization implements technical and administrative safeguards to protect employee personal data from unauthorized access, breach, alteration, or loss.²

- **Technical Controls:** All employee records are stored in encrypted databases with restricted access controls.² Multi-factor authentication, secure access logging, and regular vulnerability audits are conducted by the security operations team.¹⁷
- **Third-Party Processing:** Any third-party service provider, including payroll processors, insurance providers, or background verification agencies, is contractually bound to implement equivalent security protections.¹⁷
- **Data Minimization:** The collection of employee personal data is restricted to what is necessary for business operations and statutory compliance.¹⁷
- **Retention Boundaries:** In accordance with Section 8(7) of the DPDP Act, personal data must be erased or anonymized once the purpose of its collection has been fulfilled, unless retention is required under other statutory frameworks (such as income tax or labor laws).¹⁷
- **Breach Notification:** In the event of a personal data breach that compromises the confidentiality, integrity, or availability of employee records, the organization will notify the Data Protection Board of India (DPBI) and the affected employees, as required by law.¹⁷

Section 7.4: Grievance Redressal and Employee Data Rights

The organization has established a data grievance redressal mechanism to handle inquiries and concerns regarding personal data processing.¹⁷

Under the DPDP Act, employees have the following rights as Data Principals¹⁶:

- **Right to Access:** Employees may request a summary of their personal data processed by the organization and the list of third parties with whom it has been shared.¹⁸
- **Right to Correction:** Employees may request the correction of inaccurate, incomplete, or outdated personal data.¹⁷
- **Right to Erasure:** Employees may request the erasure of their personal data once the purpose of its collection has been fulfilled, unless retention is required by law.¹⁷

- **Right to File Grievance:** Employees may file a complaint with the designated Data Protection Officer (DPO) regarding any concerns about data handling.¹⁷

The DPO is responsible for resolving all employee data grievances within 30 days of receipt.

Chapter 8: Prevention of Sexual Harassment (POSH Act Compliance)

Section 8.1: Zero-Tolerance POSH Framework, Vision, and Scope

The organization maintains a zero-tolerance policy for sexual harassment in the workplace.⁸

This policy is framed in compliance with the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act, 2013 (the POSH Act).⁸

While the POSH Act specifically protects women, the organization extends these protections to all associates regardless of gender, enforcing a gender-neutral anti-harassment policy across all operations.²²

This policy applies to all employees (permanent, temporary, probationary, and contract-based), consultants, trainees, vendors, and visitors.² The "workplace" is defined broadly to include ⁸:

- **Physical Premises:** All offices, regional branches, and manufacturing units.²³
- **Extended Workspaces:** Any location visited by an employee during the course of their employment, including client sites, off-site conferences, business dinners, and company-sponsored social events.⁸
- **Transit:** Vehicles or transport facilities provided by the organization for commuting or official travel.⁸
- **Digital Spaces:** Virtual work environments, including video conferences, instant messaging platforms, emails, and phone calls.²³

Section 8.2: Definitions of Quid Pro Quo, Hostile Work Environment, and Misconduct

Sexual harassment includes any unwelcome, sexually explicit, or implied physical, verbal, or non-verbal conduct.⁸ Prohibited conduct includes, but is not limited to:

- **Physical Contact:** Unwelcome physical contact, advances, or touching.⁸
- **Requests for Favors:** Explicit or implied demands or requests for sexual favors.⁸
- **Verbal Misconduct:** Making sexually colored remarks, off-color jokes, or comments regarding an individual's clothing or physical appearance.⁸
- **Visual Harassment:** Showing or distributing pornographic images, offensive cartoons, or sexually suggestive digital content.⁸
- **Environmental Hostility:** Creating an intimidating, offensive, or hostile work environment through persistent unwelcome attention or comments with sexual undertones.⁸
- **Quid Pro Quo Harassment:** Linking professional opportunities, promotions, favorable performance evaluations, or continued employment to the acceptance of sexual advances, or threatening detrimental treatment for rejecting such advances.⁸

Section 8.3: Constitution and Mandate of the Internal Committee

In compliance with Section 4 of the POSH Act, the organization has established an Internal Committee (IC) at each administrative unit to receive, investigate, and redress complaints of sexual harassment.⁸

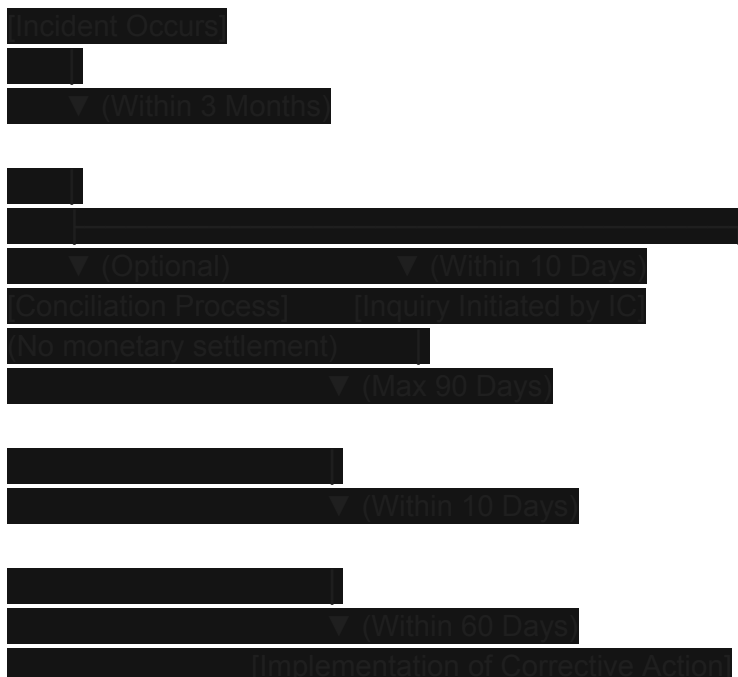
The IC is constituted of the following members:

- **Presiding Officer:** A senior female employee from the management or executive level.²²
- **Internal Members:** At least two employees who are committed to the cause of women's rights or who have experience in social work or legal matters.²²
- **External Member:** A representative from a non-governmental organization (NGO) or association committed to women's safety and gender equity, or a legal expert familiar with issues relating to sexual harassment.²²

At least one-half of the total members nominated to the IC must be women.²² The IC is vested with the powers of a civil court for the purpose of summoning witnesses, taking evidence under oath, and requiring the production of relevant documents.

Section 8.4: The Formal Complaint, Inquiry, and Redressal Procedure

The organization has established a structured timeline and procedural sequence for addressing complaints of sexual harassment, in accordance with the POSH Act.⁸



Phase	Action Required	Statutory Timeline
Filing Complaint	The complainant must submit a written, signed complaint detailing the incident(s), dates, and witnesses to any IC member. ⁸	Within 3 months of the incident (or the last incident in a series). ⁸
Conciliation	Before starting an inquiry, the IC may, at the request of the complainant, attempt to settle the matter through conciliation. ²² No monetary settlement can be the basis of conciliation. ²²	Prior to commencing formal inquiry proceedings. ²²
Inquiry	If conciliation is not requested or fails, the IC initiates a formal inquiry. ²² Both parties are given an opportunity to present witnesses and documentary evidence.	Inquiry must be completed within 90 days of the complaint. ⁸
Reporting	The IC drafts a final report detailing its findings, recommendations, and the reasoning behind its conclusions.	Report must be submitted to the management within 10 days of completing the inquiry. ⁸
Implementation	The management must execute the recommended disciplinary actions or corrective measures. ²²	Within 60 days of receiving the IC's report. ²²

During the inquiry, the IC may recommend interim relief at the written request of the complainant.²² This relief may include transferring the complainant or the respondent to another department, granting paid leave to the complainant for up to three months, or restructuring reporting lines.²²

If the inquiry establishes that the allegations are true, the IC may recommend disciplinary action, up to and including immediate termination, withholding promotions or increments, suspension, or filing a criminal complaint with the police.²²

Section 8.5: Protection Against Retaliation and Malicious Complaints

The organization prohibits any form of retaliation, harassment, or victimization against any employee who files a complaint of sexual harassment in good faith or participates in an inquiry as a witness.²² Any employee found to have engaged in retaliatory behavior will be subject to strict disciplinary action, up to and including immediate termination.²²

The POSH Act also protects individuals against false and malicious complaints.²² If the IC concludes that a complaint was made with malicious intent, or that the complainant produced forged or misleading evidence, the IC may recommend disciplinary action against the complainant.²² A lack of sufficient evidence, however, does not constitute a malicious complaint.²²

Chapter 9: Anti-Bribery, Anti-Corruption, and Vigil Mechanisms

Section 9.1: The Prevention of Corruption Act and Prohibited Financial Conduct

The organization is committed to conducting its business ethically and in compliance with the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988, and global anti-corruption standards.¹³ The organization enforces a zero-tolerance policy regarding bribery, extortion, embezzlement, and kickbacks.¹³ Key rules under the ABAC policy include:

- **Prohibited Conduct:** Employees are prohibited from offering, promising, giving, requesting, or receiving anything of value to influence a business decision or secure an improper advantage.¹³ "Anything of value" is defined broadly to include cash, cash equivalents (such as gift cards), lavish entertainment, travel expenses, or employment opportunities for relatives.¹⁵
- **Facilitation Payments:** The policy strictly prohibits "facilitation payments"—unofficial, minor payments made to government officials to secure or expedite routine administrative tasks, such as issuing licenses, visas, or utility connections.¹³
- **Interactions with Public Officials:** Interactions with public servants or government representatives are subject to strict scrutiny.¹³ No gifts, meals, or entertainment may be provided to a public official on behalf of the company without prior written approval from the designated Compliance Officer.¹³
- **Political Contributions:** The organization does not make political contributions to candidates, parties, or political committees.¹³ Employees are prohibited from making political contributions using company funds or representing the company in political matters.¹⁴

- **Third-Party Due Diligence:** Any third party representing the organization (such as agents, distributors, vendors, or consultants) must undergo comprehensive due diligence before onboarding.¹³ All third-party agreements must include anti-bribery and anti-corruption compliance clauses.¹⁴

Employees must ensure that all expenditures, business expenses, gifts, and hospitality are recorded in the organization's accounts, with supporting invoices and receipts.¹³ No off-the-books accounts or unrecorded transactions may be created.¹³

Section 9.2: Gifts, Lavish Hospitality, and Facilitation Payments

The organization has established strict guidelines regarding the acceptance of gifts and hospitality from clients, vendors, or business partners¹³:

- **Acceptable Gifts:** Employees may accept nominal gifts or hospitality (such as branded pens, calendars, or minor business meals) only if the value does not exceed regional thresholds defined by the compliance department, and the gift is not intended to influence a business decision.¹³
- **Prohibited Gifts:** Employees are strictly prohibited from accepting cash or cash equivalents, such as gift cards or stock vouchers, under any circumstances.¹⁵
- **Disclosure:** Any gift or hospitality that exceeds nominal value must be declared to the compliance department and recorded in the Corporate Gift Registry.¹³
- **Hospitality Guidelines:** Business entertainment, such as lunches, dinners, or sporting events, is permitted only if it is reasonable, directly related to business discussions, and conducted in a professional setting.¹³

Section 9.3: Third-Party Due Diligence and Compliance Controls

To protect the organization from third-party liability under anti-corruption laws, all vendors, agents, consultants, and business partners must undergo a structured compliance review before entering into a contract.¹³

The third-party compliance workflow includes:

1. **Risk Assessment:** The business unit initiating the vendor relationship conducts an initial risk assessment based on the vendor's location, services, and interaction with public officials.¹⁵
2. **Due Diligence Questionnaire:** The vendor must complete a comprehensive due diligence questionnaire disclosing their ownership structure, past legal compliance, and anti-bribery policies.¹⁴
3. **Background Verification:** The compliance team reviews the vendor's financial records, legal history, and public reputation.¹⁵
4. **Contractual Protections:** All vendor agreements must include standard anti-bribery and anti-corruption compliance clauses, permitting the organization to audit the vendor's records and terminate the agreement in the event of a breach.¹⁴

Section 9.4: The Vigil Mechanism and Whistleblower Policy

In compliance with Section 177 of the Companies Act, 2013, the organization has established a Vigil Mechanism and Whistleblower Policy.²⁷ This mechanism allows employees, directors, and external partners to report concerns regarding unethical behavior, financial fraud, systemic corruption, or violations of this handbook without fear of retaliation.¹³

The whistleblower mechanism operates under the following guidelines:

- **Reporting Channels:** Whistleblowers can report concerns directly to the designated Compliance Officer or submit an anonymous report through the company's secure whistleblower portal.¹⁵ In exceptional cases involving financial fraud or executive misconduct, reports can be submitted directly to the Audit Committee Chairman.
- **Protection from Retaliation:** The organization prohibits any form of retaliation, discrimination, or adverse employment action against an individual who reports a concern in good faith.¹⁵ Any employee who retaliates against a whistleblower will be subject to disciplinary action, up to and including termination.²²
- **Investigation Process:** Upon receipt of a report, the Compliance Officer will initiate a confidential investigation.¹⁵ The whistleblower's identity will remain confidential to the extent permitted by the investigation and applicable laws.¹⁵
- **Action and Reporting:** The findings of whistleblower investigations are reported to the Audit Committee on a quarterly basis, alongside recommendations for corrective or legal actions.¹⁵

Chapter 10: Compensation, Health, and Social Security Benefits

Section 10.1: Payroll Schedules, Classifications, and Tax Withholdings

The organization's compensation structure is designed to reward performance while ensuring compliance with national wage standards and the Code on Wages.²

- **Disbursement Schedule:** Salaries are computed on a monthly basis and disbursed directly to employees' designated bank accounts on or before the last working day of each calendar month.²
- **Salary Slips:** Detailed electronic salary slips are made available to employees on the disbursement date, outlining basic pay, dearness allowance, bonuses, and statutory deductions.²
- **Tax Withholdings:** The payroll department processes all mandatory tax withholdings, including Tax Deducted at Source (TDS), Professional Tax (PT), and other regional social security levies, in accordance with applicable tax laws.¹⁷
- **Wage Attachments:** The organization complies with all lawful wage attachments and garnishment orders issued by courts or government authorities, notifying the affected employee in writing.²¹

Section 10.2: Employee Provident Fund (EPF) and Social Security

Deductions

For eligible employees in India, the organization administers social security benefits in compliance with the Employees' Provident Funds and Miscellaneous Provisions Act, 1952.³⁰ Under the EPF scheme³⁰:

$$\text{Employee Contribution} = 12\% \times (\text{Basic Salary} + \text{Dearness Allowance})$$

$$\text{Employer Contribution} = 12\% \times (\text{Basic Salary} + \text{Dearness Allowance})$$

The employee's contribution is deducted automatically from their monthly gross salary.³⁰ The employer's contribution of 12% is paid directly by the organization, with a portion (8.33%) allocated to the Employees' Pension Scheme (EPS) and the remainder (3.67%) deposited into the Employee Provident Fund account, subject to statutory limits.³⁰

Section 10.3: ERISA and Group Health Insurance Compliance (US Workforce)

For personnel employed within the United States, the organization's benefit programs are administered in compliance with the Employee Retirement Income Security Act (ERISA).³ ERISA protects the interests of employees enrolled in employer-sponsored health, retirement, and welfare benefit plans by establishing standards of conduct for plan fiduciaries and requiring transparency in reporting.³

The organization also complies with the Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA), ensuring the confidentiality and security of employees' protected health information (PHI).³ Employees enrolled in the company's group health insurance plans receive a Summary Plan Description (SPD) outlining coverage, deductibles, copayments, and the process for submitting medical claims.³

Section 10.4: The Payment of Gratuity Act Compliance (India Workforce)

In compliance with the Payment of Gratuity Act, 1972, the organization provides a statutory gratuity benefit to employees as a monetary reward for long-term service.²⁹

Statutory Eligibility

To qualify for gratuity, an employee must complete at least 5 years of continuous service with the organization.²⁹ The 5-year requirement is waived if employment is terminated due to the employee's death or permanent disablement caused by an accident or disease.²⁹ For seasonal or six-day workweek operations, employees who have worked at least 240 days in a given year are considered to have completed a full year of continuous service.²⁹

Gratuity Formula

For employees covered under the Act, the statutory gratuity benefit is calculated using the following formula²⁹:

$$\text{Gratuity} = \frac{\text{Last Drawn Salary} \times 15 \times \text{Completed Years of Service}}{26}$$

Where:

- **Last Drawn Salary** is defined as the employee's monthly Basic Salary plus Dearness Allowance.²⁹ All other allowances, bonuses, and commissions are excluded from the calculation.³²
- The divisor of **26** represents the standard number of working days in a month (excluding Sundays).²⁹
- The multiplier of **15** represents 15 days of wages for each completed year of service.²⁹
- **Completed Years of Service** is rounded to the nearest whole year.³² Any period of service exceeding 6 months in the final year is rounded up to a full year.³² For example, a tenure of 8 years and 7 months is rounded up to 9 years of service.³²

Statutory Ceilings and Tax Exemptions

The maximum tax-free gratuity payable under Section 10(10) of the Income Tax Act, 1961, is capped at ₹25,00,000.³² Any gratuity amount received in excess of this statutory limit is subject to income tax.³¹

Forfeiture of Gratuity

In accordance with Section 4(6) of the Payment of Gratuity Act, the organization may forfeit an employee's accrued gratuity, either partially or fully, if the employee is terminated for:

1. Gross misconduct, riotous behavior, or acts of physical violence.²⁹
2. Committing an offense involving moral turpitude, provided the offense is committed during the course of employment.³²
3. Intentionally causing damage, destruction, or financial loss to the organization's property.³² Forfeiture is limited to the extent of the financial damage caused.²⁹

The organization will disburse all eligible gratuity payments within 30 days of the date the benefit becomes due (e.g., the employee's last working day).³²

Section 10.5: Workers' Compensation, Unemployment, and Safety

The organization provides insurance coverage to support employees in the event of work-related injuries or involuntary separation²:

- **Workers' Compensation:** In compliance with regional workers' compensation laws, the organization provides medical coverage and wage-replacement benefits to employees who sustain work-related injuries or illnesses.² Employees must report any workplace

accident or injury to their supervisor and the HR department within 24 hours of the incident, regardless of severity.⁴

- **Unemployment Insurance:** The organization contributes to federal and state-level unemployment insurance programs, providing short-term financial assistance to eligible workers who experience involuntary job loss.²¹
- **Workplace Safety and Health:** The organization is committed to maintaining a safe work environment, in compliance with occupational health and safety standards.² Employees must follow safety protocols, participate in required training, and report safety hazards or equipment malfunctions immediately to the facilities team.¹

Chapter 11: Performance Appraisals, Training, and Development

Section 11.1: Performance Management Cycle and KPI Alignments

The organization maintains a structured performance management system designed to evaluate employee contributions, support professional development, and align individual goals with corporate objectives.¹

Phase	Timeframe	Key Activities	Expected Outcomes
Phase I: Goal Setting ²	Q1 (Annual Start) ²	Employee and manager align on Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) and developmental objectives. ²	Approved, documented performance plan in the HR system. ¹
Phase II: Mid-Year Review ²	Q3 (Mid-Year) ²	Conduct a progress check, provide constructive feedback, and adjust goals based on operational shifts. ¹	Documented performance feedback and adjusted targets.
Phase III: Self-Evaluation	Q4 (Year-End)	Employee completes a self-assessment of achievements against established	Submitted self-appraisal form.

		KPIs. ¹	
Phase IV: Annual Review ²	Q1 (Year-End Close) ²	Formal review meeting between employee and manager; determination of overall performance rating. ¹	Final appraisal score informing compensation changes. ²

Performance appraisals are evaluated based on objective, measurable performance standards and the organization's core values.² Employees who consistently exceed performance benchmarks may be eligible for promotions, bonuses, and salary increments.²

Section 11.2: Employee Training and Continuous Learning

The organization supports professional development through continuous learning.¹

The professional development framework includes:

- **On-the-Job Training:** Regular technical workshops and skills-based training designed to enhance job performance.²
- **Professional Certifications:** Financial support or reimbursement may be provided for pre-approved professional certifications, licenses, or examinations directly relevant to the employee's role.¹
- **Leadership Development:** Tailored leadership training programs for managers and high-potential employees to build capabilities in management and operational strategy.¹
- **E-Learning Portal:** Access to the corporate e-learning platform, offering professional courses in technical skills, project management, and compliance.¹

Employees must obtain written approval from their manager and the human resources department before enrolling in any reimbursable training or certification program.¹

Section 11.3: Corporate Travel and Expense Reimbursement Guidelines

The organization reimburses employees for reasonable and necessary business expenses incurred during the performance of their duties.¹

Key expense reimbursement guidelines include:

- **Travel Authorization:** All business travel, including flights, hotel bookings, and vehicle rentals, must be pre-approved in writing by the department head.
- **Eligible Expenses:** Standard reimbursable expenses include commercial airfare (economy class), moderate lodging, business meals within defined daily limits, and public transit or taxi fares.¹
- **Personal Vehicles:** Employees who use their personal vehicles for business travel are eligible for mileage reimbursement at standard, regional rates.

- **Submitting Claims:** Expense reports, accompanied by receipts, must be submitted through the corporate expense management portal within 15 days of completing the travel.¹

Section 11.4: Company Car and Parking Allotments

The organization provides guidelines for the allotment and use of company vehicles and parking facilities ²:

- **Company Car Allotment:** Company vehicles may be provided to eligible executives, sales personnel, or operational staff based on the requirements of their roles.² Employees assigned a company vehicle must maintain a valid driver's license, follow vehicle maintenance schedules, and comply with the corporate Fleet Safety Policy.² Personal use of company vehicles is restricted and must be logged.²
- **Parking Allotments:** Parking spaces at corporate facilities are allocated based on seniority, operational needs, or carpool participation.² Employees must register their vehicles with facilities management to receive a parking permit.² The organization is not liable for theft, damage, or loss of personal property in corporate parking lots.²

Chapter 12: Separation, Disciplinary Actions, and Offboarding

Section 12.1: Probationary Period and Confirmation Process

Every newly hired employee undergoes an initial probationary period of six months, unless specified otherwise in their employment agreement.⁶ During probation, the supervisor evaluates the employee's performance, technical skills, and behavioral alignment.⁶

The probation process operates under the following rules:

- **Termination Notice:** During the probationary period, either the employee or the organization may terminate the employment relationship by providing seven days of written notice.⁶
- **Probation Extension:** If the supervisor determines that the employee's performance requires further evaluation, the organization may extend the probationary period in writing for an additional, defined period, up to a maximum of six months.
- **Confirmation:** Upon successful completion of the probationary period, the human resources department will issue a formal, written Confirmation of Employment.⁶

Section 12.2: Notice Periods for Resignation and Involuntary Termination

For confirmed permanent employees, the termination or resignation notice period is governed by local labor laws, including the Karnataka Shops and Commercial Establishments Act, 1961.⁶

The notice period framework requires:

- **Confirmed Employees:** Confirmed personnel must provide a minimum of thirty days' written notice of resignation, unless a longer notice period is specified in their employment

contract.⁶

- **Involuntary Separation:** The organization must provide a minimum of thirty days' written notice, or pay in lieu of notice, for any involuntary separation, except in cases of summary dismissal for gross misconduct.⁶
- **Notice of Dismissal:** Under Section 39 of the Karnataka Act, no employee who has put in continuous service for a period of not less than six months can be dismissed except for a reasonable cause, and unless they have received at least one month's notice in writing or pay in lieu thereof.⁷
- **Exceptions for Misconduct:** If an employee is dismissed for proven misconduct, they are not entitled to notice or pay in lieu of notice.⁷

Section 12.3: Disciplinary Action, Show-Cause Notices, and Domestic Inquiry

The organization has established a disciplinary procedure to address performance issues, behavioral violations, and misconduct in a fair and legally compliant manner.⁶

The progressive disciplinary sequence consists of the following actions:

1. **Verbal Warning:** For minor violations or performance issues, the supervisor conducts a private meeting to issue a verbal warning. The warning is documented in the manager's files.
2. **Written Warning:** For repeated minor infractions or a more serious single incident, a formal written warning is issued by the manager and human resources, and placed in the employee's personnel file.
3. **Suspension:** For severe violations or during the investigation of alleged gross misconduct, the employee may be suspended pending investigation, with or without pay, in accordance with applicable laws.
4. **Summary Dismissal:** For proven gross misconduct or failure to correct performance issues, the employee's services are terminated.⁶

In cases of alleged gross misconduct, the organization must follow a structured Domestic Inquiry process before executing a summary dismissal to ensure due process⁶:

- **Show-Cause Notice:** The employee is issued a formal, written show-cause notice detailing the specific charges and allegations of misconduct.⁶
- **Response Period:** The employee is given a reasonable period, typically 48 to 72 hours, to submit a written explanation in response to the charges.
- **Inquiry Committee:** If the employee's response is unsatisfactory, an independent Inquiry Committee is constituted to examine the evidence and hear witnesses.⁶ The employee has the right to present their case, cross-examine witnesses, and review all evidence.
- **Findings and Decision:** The Inquiry Committee submits its findings and report to management.²⁸ If the charges of misconduct are proven, management may proceed with summary dismissal or implement other disciplinary actions, such as demotion or withholding increments.²²

During the inquiry, the organization may place the employee under suspension, during which

they may be entitled to a subsistence allowance in accordance with applicable laws.

Section 12.4: Full and Final Settlements, Clearance, and Return of Property

Upon separation from the organization, whether through resignation or termination, employees must complete a structured offboarding process.²

- **Return of Company Property:** Employees must return all company-issued assets, including laptops, mobile devices, security access badges, keys, corporate credit cards, and physical or digital documents, on or before their last working day.²
- **Data Erasure:** Employees must cooperate with the IT department to ensure all corporate data is removed from personal devices.²
- **Exit Interview:** The human resources department may conduct an exit interview to gather feedback and facilitate a smooth transition.¹
- **Full and Final Settlement:** In accordance with the Code on Wages, the organization will calculate and disburse all outstanding payments, including final wages, accrued and encashable leaves, and gratuity (if eligible), within 2 working days of the employee's last day of employment.²⁸
- **Dues Clearance:** Any outstanding financial obligations of the employee to the company, such as salary advances or unreturned equipment costs, will be reconciled and deducted from the final settlement, subject to statutory limits.²

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